



MIDNIGHT ABYSS

QUICKSTART RULES



Welcome to the Abyss

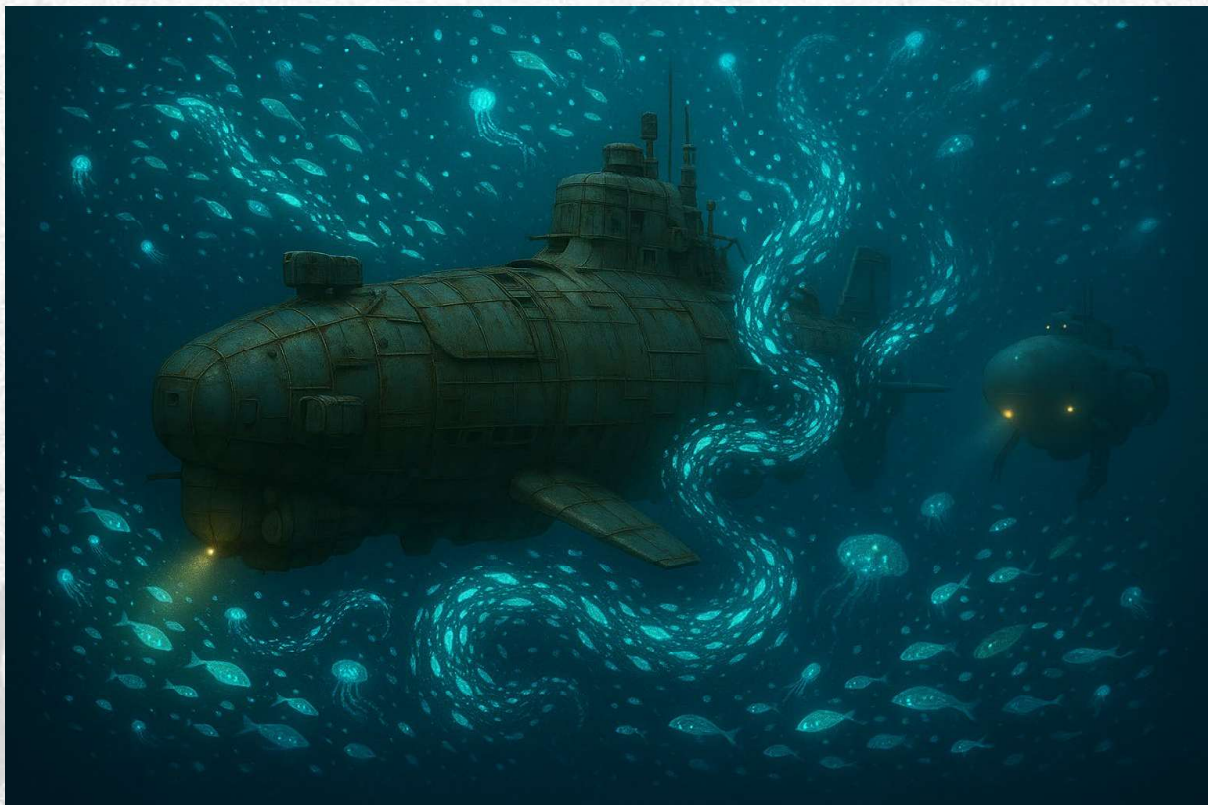
The surface still endures, but it can no longer sustain the billions who once lived there. Storms batter the coastlines, harvests fail, and cities crumble beneath polluted skies. Most of humanity has descended into the deep, carving out domes, stations, and subs to replace what the land can no longer give.

The abyss is not just an ocean. It is a new world, one of pressure, darkness, scarcity, and isolation. This quickstart offers a first descent into that world, giving you the essential rules and enough of the setting to understand why people risk everything below the waves.

You will play as divers, salvagers, and explorers — those who go where others dare not. Their lives are marked by rationed oxygen, rusting hulls, and flickering lamps, but also by daring and discovery.

This is not a book of every rule. It is a primer, a way to taste the world and feel its weight. Here you will learn to breathe shallow, to trust your crew, and to stare into the black where something vast may stir.

Gather your team. Seal the hatch. The abyss is waiting.



A Story from the Deep

The hull groaned again, louder this time. Mira froze, her hand pressed to the cold steel, feeling the vibration crawl up her arm and settle in her chest. The others stopped too. The only sound in the cabin was the shallow, uneven rhythm of breathing through masks.

The sonar flickered, screen painting and erasing shapes too large to make sense of. A blotch here, a line there — and then, for a heartbeat, something vast. A silhouette that stretched from edge to edge, shifting like smoke in water. Mira blinked and it was gone.

“Keep her steady,” the Captain whispered. His voice was calm, but his eyes never left the readout. “We finish the cut, then we go.”

The salvage torch flared to life again, bathing the wreck’s ruptured flank in harsh white light. Tiny particles shimmered and drifted like dust in a cathedral. Mira leaned forward, peering through the viewport at the ruin before them. Once it had been a transport — thick hull plating, cargo racks still clinging to their frames. Now it was a mausoleum, half-buried in the silt of the trench wall.

Her pulse thudded in her ears as she worked the controls. Grapples locked. The torch cut deeper. The wreck seemed to sigh, releasing a faint stream of bubbles that curled past the viewport and vanished into the endless black.

And beneath it all, the pressure sang. She could feel it even through the suit’s

dampeners — an ache in her bones, a weight behind her eyes. The abyss was patient, but it was always listening. Always pressing.

A shape moved in the corner of her vision. Not on sonar this time — through the glass itself. Something pale, ribbon-thin, sliding just beyond the reach of their lights. She jerked her head, but the shadows swallowed it whole.

Another groan. This one from the wreck, not their own hull. The cut was nearly complete. Mira imagined the chamber beyond: crates swollen with pressure, or perhaps already hollow, stripped long ago. It did not matter. Anything salvageable was worth risking. Oxygen was low. Supplies lower. Without this haul, there might not be a next dive.

The lights flickered. For half a second the cabin was plunged into true darkness. In that instant Mira felt it: something vast, pressing against the submersible, invisible but real. When the lamps returned, nothing had changed. The wreck loomed silent. The sonar screen was blank.

The Captain cleared his throat. “No delays. Bring it in.”

No one replied. They did not need to. In the abyss, time itself felt heavier. Every second was borrowed. Every moment was risk. And somewhere beyond the hull, in the dark that no lamp could touch, something moved...



Collapse and Descent

The world above the waves fractured long before the abyss became home. Rising seas swept away low-lying nations. Unpredictable storms chewed through coastlines, displacing millions. The food chains broke as fisheries collapsed, farmland drowned, and once-reliable weather patterns dissolved into chaos. Governments found themselves overwhelmed, their authority eroded alongside the land itself. What followed was a slow unravelling — borders hardened, then dissolved; alliances crumbled; cities turned inward, cut off and starving.

Humanity's salvation was not found in rebuilding the land, but in abandoning it. First came the shallow domes: desperate projects sealed against the sea, clinging to the continental shelves and powered by scavenged reactors. Then came the floating

platforms, converted oil rigs and welded-together flotillas offering only a fragile refuge from the storms above. The trenches beckoned next, deep bases sunk into volcanic seams or geothermal vents, trading daylight for stability.

Generations have now passed since that descent. The surface is little more than a rumour, a place of wreckage and uninhabitable wastelands. The new world is defined not by nations, but by the capacity to endure the abyss. Oxygen, food, and fuel dictate power more absolutely than borders ever did. Factions rise and fall not through ideology but through their ability to harvest, control, or deny these essential lifelines.

The abyss is no longer an unexplored frontier. It is the only home humanity has left.

The Tone of Survival

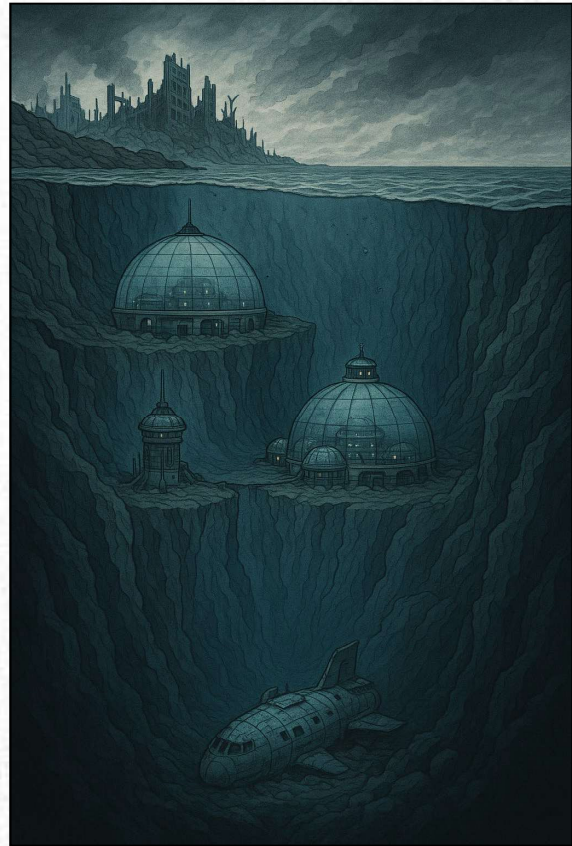
Life in the abyss is fragile. Every breath, every calorie, every hour of warmth is hard-earned. Settlements may claim to endure, but survival is never permanent — only prolonged. Player characters are not the comfortable majority. They are the ones willing to risk everything, daring to step beyond the fortified domes and risk the abyss itself. To understand their lives, four truths must always be remembered.

Pressure

At the abyssal depths, where the ocean floor stretches out in silence and darkness, the sea begins to remind humanity of its fragility. Hulls creak and steel strains as if alive, groaning against the weight above. Descend deeper, into the hadal depths where trenches plunge beyond imagination, and the ocean does not forgive. Diving suits bend and creak under forces no human body could ever endure. Even the most advanced equipment has limits, and when those limits are breached, death arrives instantly. To work in the deep is to exist in constant negotiation with pressure itself — an endless, invisible hand pressing in from every direction, reminding all who venture there that the abyss always wins in the end.

Darkness

Light is a luxury that fails quickly. Beyond the reach of lamps and sonar, there is only shadow. In the abyss, darkness is not absence but presence: a cloak that hides predators, ruins, and phenomena that defy understanding. The black swallows scale and distance, making every encounter uncertain.



Scarcity

Resources can be finite, potentially dwindling. Settlements raise algae, pen fish, and recycle air with scrubbers, but a single accident, raid, or storm can plunge entire communities into famine. Crews who venture out are scavengers as much as explorers, relying on salvage, barter, and luck to secure their next dive.

Isolation

Every dome, submersible, and station is a fragile bubble in a hostile world. Distances are vast, communications unreliable, and reinforcements unlikely. Trust is rare, and betrayal is common. Humanity survives not in unity, but in scattered enclaves that cling to life in the black.



The Factions at a Glance

Though the abyss is scattered and fragmented, four great powers dominate the world. No one controls everything, but each commands enough strength, territory, and loyalty to shape life in the depths. Player characters will almost always have lived under one of them, traded with them, or fled from their reach. None are truly secure, but each offers its own fragile vision of survival.

The Oceanic Union

The clerk dipped his stylus into the inkpot and signed the form. “Your breath allotment has been recalculated. Report for adjustment.” Behind him, a wall of brass dials clicked softly, tracking the exhalations of every citizen in the dome. The diver clenched his fists. A day’s oxygen — gone with a pen stroke.



Overview:

The Oceanic Union claims to be civilisation reborn — the heir to the drowned nations of the surface. Its domes are orderly, its bureaucracy vast, and its rhetoric steeped in the language of citizenship and rights. Every chamber is catalogued, every ration tallied, every citizen monitored in endless ledgers and electronic archives. Inside Union territory, life is tightly regulated. Food is distributed by quota, and every action leaves a trail of paperwork. Yet this structure has allowed entire generations to grow up within brightly lit halls, surrounded by the illusion of safety and predictability.

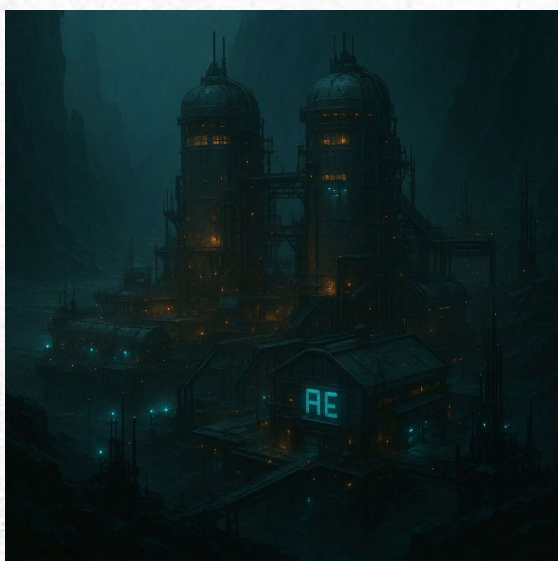
In Play:

To its citizens, the Union is stability. Its domes are clean, its corridors brightly lit, and its systems, though harsh, keep starvation at bay. They can expect order, schooling for their children, and at least the promise that tomorrow will resemble today. To outsiders, however, the Union is suffocating bureaucracy — cold, merciless, and quick to discard those who do not fit its calculations. Rumours spread of whistle-blowers silenced, salvage captains erased from records, and whole domes abandoned as “inefficient.” Crews may find themselves dealing with Union officials for permits, contracts, or safe passage, but the Union never gives anything freely. Every bargain is weighed, documented, and stamped in triplicate, and those who resist its rules often discover the full reach of its control.



Abyssal Corp

The contract was signed on a slab of reinforced glass, suspended above the dockyard. Rows of Posiden-class subs sat in cradles below, welders. A woman in a pristine pressure suit smiled thinly as she pressed her hand to the biometric seal. “Delivery guaranteed,” she said, “on time and under cost.” Behind her, the sound of rivets hammering echoed like a heartbeat through the abyss.



What Outsiders Whisper About Abyssal Corp

“They will sell you a submersible as easily as they would a coffin. Sometimes it is the same thing.”

“They cut corners, they cut steel, they cut wages. What they never cut is profit.”

Overview

Abyssal Corp is the industrial spine of the abyss, a vast conglomerate whose shipyards and factories cling to trench walls and domes alike. They specialise in mass production of submersibles, habitat modules, and the infrastructure that keeps humanity alive below the waves. The

ubiquitous Posiden-class was their creation: cheap to build, reliable enough to survive, and flawed enough to keep crews cursing the company’s name.

To its leadership, survival is a market. Abyssal Corp believes the abyss can be endured through scale, logistics, and relentless efficiency. Contracts are their scripture, welders their acolytes, and quotas their creed. Their yards never sleep. Workers labour in shifts that blur together, patching hulls and stamping out new machines in an endless rhythm. To outsiders, their products look sturdy but uninspired — practical coffins of steel built to keep people alive just long enough to pay off the lease.

In Play

For player characters, Abyssal Corp represents both lifeline and threat. Their vessels, tools, and modules are everywhere, often the only affordable choice for independent crews. Yet every rivet carries the shadow of compromise: cheap alloys, rushed welds, and cost-saving designs that place lives at risk. Crews who deal with the corporation may find contracts easy to obtain but hard to escape. To work with Abyssal Corp is to accept a bargain — survival at a price, and never quite on your own terms.



The Northern Shield Coalition

“Hold your post,” barked the officer. The young recruit’s rifle shook in her hands as the sonar pinged again and again. Out beyond the trench wall, something vast shifted. The Shield did not retreat. They never did.

Overview:



The Coalition began as scattered military remnants clinging to survival in the chaos after the fall of the surface world. Over time they welded themselves into a defensive bloc, bound together by a creed of strength, vigilance, and sacrifice.

They teach that only discipline and readiness stand between humanity and extinction. Their domes bristle with weapons, defensive turrets line the corridors, and their patrol submarines sweep the black waters in endless circuits. Every child grows up drilled in combat

and survival skills, expected to serve as soldier, technician, or officer. In the Coalition, even art and education serve the purpose of reinforcing unity and the constant message that danger waits at the gates.

In Play:

Life in the Shield is strict but communal. Families know their children will serve, their contributions judged not by personal ambition but by what strengthens the bloc. Outsiders often describe Shield folk as grim, humourless, and obsessed with threats that may never come, yet when the abyss presses close it is the Coalition that stands firm, guns levelled and formations unbroken.

For characters, the Shield may be both protector and oppressor. They offer safety, strongholds, and allies who will never retreat, but they demand obedience, conformity, and the surrender of individuality in return. Trust the Shield, and you live. Defy them, and you are alone.



The Pelagic League

A lantern swung in the salt breeze. Music rose from a raft strung with patchwork banners. A child painted shells as traders shouted prices, and in the chaos, a smuggler slipped a sealed package beneath a net. In the League, everything was barter, and everything was alive.



Overview:

The League is a riot of colour in the dark. Its floats and cavern-settlements are markets, festivals, and brawls all at once. Salvage and improvisation are its lifeblood. Nothing in the League is permanent, but everything has meaning. A patched raft can become a home. A broken tool, a story. A song, a bond between strangers. Lanterns swing above ramshackle docks, paint drips from corrugated steel, and the air is thick with

the scent of cooking fires, salt, and sweat. Drums echo across the water, laughter rises from crowded barges, and painted banners flutter where the currents can reach.

In Play:

To its people, the League is freedom, the chance to live without permits or quotas, where a person's worth is measured by what they bring and how they share it. Anyone may carve a place if they contribute, no matter their past. To outsiders, it is reckless, piratical, and dangerous — a carnival of contradictions. Generosity and betrayal walk hand in hand, and a feast one night may turn into a knife fight the next. For characters, the League offers wild opportunity: a life unbound by rigid rules, brilliant and precarious, always on the edge of collapse or celebration, forever teetering between danger and joy. Here, survival feels immediate, electric, and alive, as if every dive and every trade might change a crew's fate forever.



The Trench Confederacy

The diver's light fell on a wall of carved steel spirals. At the centre stood an elder, his face tattooed in glowing ink. He raised his hands, and silence swept the chamber. "The abyss tests us," he intoned. "Only those who endure may remain."

What Outsiders Whisper About the Confederacy

"Every scar on their hulls is a prayer, every patch another vow. They don't repair — they consecrate."

"They claim the abyss speaks to them in pressure and stillness. Maybe that's madness. Maybe that's survival."

Overview

The Confederacy clings to trench walls and geothermal vents, carving sanctuaries of steel and ritual into the abyss. Their settlements resemble fortress-monasteries: reinforced with salvaged plating, lit by faint halogen strips, and shaped as much by devotion as necessity. Life here is austere and insular. Resources are shared sparingly, silence is respected, and every repair or breath feels like an act of reverence. To the Confederacy, survival is not only practical — it is spiritual. Endurance itself is faith, pressure is a teacher, and the abyss is no empty void but a presence to be endured and revered.



In Play:

For player characters, the Confederacy is both mystery and menace. Outsiders often brand them zealots, half-mad from pressure and silence. Yet those who meet them find something else: calm intensity, unshakable conviction, and a refusal to lie or compromise. Every dive, every exchange of oxygen, is framed as a sacred trial — a communion with the crushing dark. Crews who cross paths with the Confederacy may find them terrifying neighbours, but also steadfast allies when trust is earned. To work alongside them is to glimpse a vision of survival bound not by wealth or might, but by devotion to the abyss itself.

What the Characters Know

Every crew has their own opinions of the factions. Some may have grown up inside their domes. Others may have fled their reach. Some crews work for them, others against them. Whatever the case, the factions are too large to ignore. They are the tides of the abyss, and player characters are the ones who must decide whether to swim with them, against them, or between them.

Life in the Abyss

A Vignette from the Depths

The lights flickered once, then again, and the mess hall fell silent. Everyone turned their heads to the ceiling where water beaded on the joints, waiting for the hiss of escaping air. It did not come. Instead, the old scrubbers rattled and groaned before resuming their steady hum.

Jaro exhaled and picked up his bowl again. The algae stew tasted of iron, but it was hot, and that was enough. Across the table, his daughter mended a torn pressure suit with copper wire stripped from a wreck. Beside her, an old diver told a story of a swarm of razor eels that had stripped a man to bone in less than a minute.

“Stories keep us sharp,” the elder said. “The abyss does not forgive the foolish.”

Everyone nodded, and in that moment, the dim hall felt like the whole world: metal walls, humming pumps, and the endless black pressing close on every side.

Daily Survival

To endure in the abyss is to live inside a fragile cage. Domes, corridors, and submersibles are fragile shells, never meant to last forever, and they demand constant care. Every breath taken is borrowed time. Every bite eaten is the work of countless hands.

Food is basic and repetitive. Algae farms grow in stacked vats, tended under the glow of scavenged lamps. Fish are penned in pressure tanks, their bones grown brittle but edible. Hydroponics towers cling to the interiors of domes, yielding leaves pale and stringy but rich with nutrients. On good days, there might be broth of kelp and crab, or a haul of fresh lanternfish

caught in the nets of a daring crew. On bad days, meals are boiled algae pressed into cakes, chewed in silence.

Oxygen is the one true currency. Cylinders are weighed with reverence, their valves checked with ritual care. A diver's first act each day is to test their tanks and listen to the soft hiss of air. Scrubbers hum endlessly, pulling carbon dioxide from the recycled atmosphere, and their maintenance is a holy duty. To waste air is a crime; to hoard it is worse. Settlements enforce rationing not through laws but through necessity — for when air runs low, all suffer together.

Repairs dominate life. Children are raised with wrenches in their hands, learning to patch leaks with resin, to weld with salvaged tools, to splice wires pulled from drowned towers. Rust is a constant enemy, creeping across steel and eating at the hull. Every creak of metal in the dark reminds the people that nothing lasts forever.

Resource Gathering

Beyond the domes lies hunger, opportunity, and death. Divers venture into the black not out of choice but necessity, for the abyss gives nothing freely.

Spear fishing remains a staple. Divers venture into flooded caves or drag nets behind subs, catching eel shoals or jellyfish that glow faintly in the dark. The risks are great: predators stalk the same waters, drawn by the scent of blood or the vibrations of struggling prey.

Salvage is more dangerous still, but far more rewarding. Every wreck is a trove of steel, copper, tools, and relics. Guilds mark claims, and rivals circle like sharks, ready to fight for anything of value. Some

wrecks collapse without warning, sending divers scrambling for safety. Others hide predators that have made the hull their lair. Still, salvage feeds settlements in ways algae never can, and many crews live or die by what they can haul from the past.

Trading ties everything together. Floating markets and hidden coves bustle with barter, with oxygen cylinders traded for food, with scrap metal exchanged for weapons, with data sold for secrets. Here, fortunes rise and fall on a single deal, and allegiances are as fragile as the domes themselves.

Ordinary Divers and Player Characters

Most who live beneath the waves cling to routine. They mend nets, tend algae farms, and scrape rust from the walls. They dive shallow, never straying far from the safety of their domes. Their ambitions stretch no further than surviving another cycle,

raising their children, and trusting that their community will hold. They are survivors, but nothing more.

Player characters are different. They are those who take risks others will not, who cut open ancient wrecks in search of lost wealth, who trade in places marked forbidden, who dive into trenches where maps are little more than rumour. They are freebooters, scavengers, smugglers, and explorers, united by hunger and daring. Where others look away from the dark, they stare into it.

The difference is not strength or training alone, though many characters will have both. It is a refusal to accept life as it is given. They risk their lives for a chance at more: more oxygen, more food, more knowledge, or perhaps more meaning. This drive sets them apart from the ordinary folk of the abyss, and it ensures that their stories are worth telling.



Crews of the Abyss

A Crew in Motion

The lamps lit the wreck like a stage. Two divers cut through twisted plating, sparks clouding the water. In the sub above, Lian tapped the sonar screen, watching an impossible shadow slide along the trench wall.

“Keep working,” she said into the comm. Her voice was steady, though her hands shook.

Below, the cutter cursed as his torch sputtered, oxygen gauges blinking amber. His partner laughed, hollow inside his mask. The wreck groaned, shedding a plume of silt that swallowed their lights. For a moment, nothing existed but grey cloud and the sound of their own breath.

Then the shadow moved again. Larger this time. Close enough that the water seemed to tremble. Lian swallowed, forcing her voice calm. “One more plate,” she said. “Then we’re done.”

The divers exchanged a glance that said everything. They could cut, or they could run — and in the abyss, hesitation was death. The torch flared back to life. Sparks bloomed like stars in the dark.

Above them, the dark pressed closer. The shadow turned.

Why Crews Exist

The abyss is vast, hostile, and merciless. No settlement can survive by its own walls alone. It is the crews who tie the world together — small groups who dare to travel between domes, salvage wrecks, and trade where others will not.

Crews exist because mobility is power. Submersibles are fragile, but they can slip past blockades, escape storms, or vanish into the black. Where settlements are tethered to the rock, crews move like currents, carrying knowledge, supplies, and danger in equal measure.

Crews exist because someone must take the risks that others refuse. Most folk live close to home, tending algae farms or repairing bulkheads, and rarely stray far beyond their domes. Their lives unfold along the ocean floor and trench walls, in settlements where every breath is rationed and every patch of steel holds back the abyss. But oxygen runs out, machines fail, predators encroach. When settlements need something beyond their reach — spare parts, weapons, fuel, rare fish, or data slates — it is the crews who dive into the dark to find it.

Crews exist because scavenging is survival. Almost every piece of functioning technology in the abyss comes from a wreck or ruin. The oceans are littered with the bones of drowned ships, stations, and even entire cities. Crews pry open those bones, pulling life from rust, steel, and memory. Without them, settlements would collapse into hunger and silence.

To be part of a crew is to stand apart from ordinary divers. Crews live by their wits, their nerve, and their trust in one another. They are not heroes, at least not in the stories they tell. They are survivors who refuse to stay inside the walls, gamblers who place their lives on every dive. In the abyss, their courage and recklessness shape the stories worth telling.

Sample Crew Archetypes

Not every crew looks the same. Some cling to rules, others thrive in chaos, but all share a bond forged in pressure and darkness. Here are a few common archetypes players might use for inspiration:

Freebooters

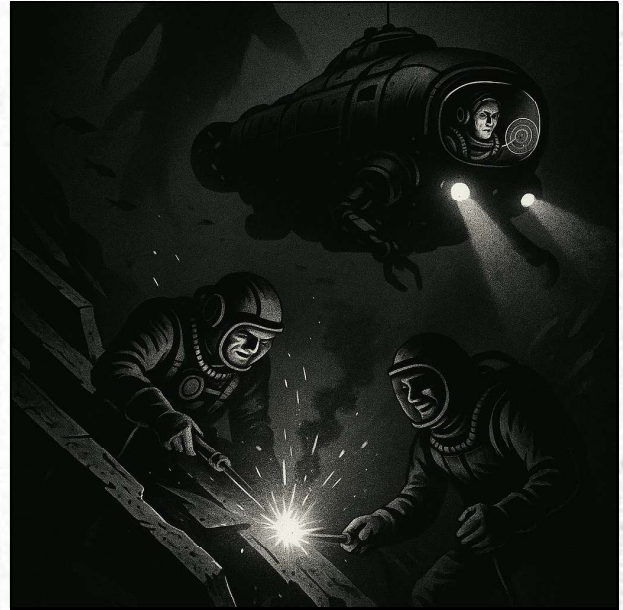
These are the independents, wandering where they please. Freebooters answer to no flag or faction, living from salvage and barter. They carry a reputation for being unreliable and opportunistic, but also daring enough to pull off dives that others would never attempt. They thrive on adaptability, surviving where larger powers cannot reach.

Scouts

Some crews specialise in exploration. Scouts chart new routes, probe deep canyons, and carry messages between settlements. They are often hired as guides or surveyors, but their true passion lies in discovery. Scouts are respected, but many whisper that they see too much — things that should be left alone.

Guild-bound Crews

The Salvager Guilds claim dominion over wrecks, and their bound crews enforce that claim. These crews are better equipped than most, but they live under suffocating rules and debts. Every bolt they pry loose is tallied, every cargo sealed and recorded. To serve in a guild crew is to be caught between the protection of an empire and the suffocation of its grip.



Smugglers

Trade is the lifeblood of the abyss, but the Union and the Corps tax it to the bone. Smugglers slip between the cracks, running contraband oxygen tanks, forbidden relics, or even people. They are clever, reckless, and fiercely loyal to those who pay well. Smugglers carry the scent of danger, for betrayal or exposure can mean a quick death in the black.

These archetypes are not limits, but starting points. Crews in play may blend them all — a guild crew that smuggles on the side, freebooters who scout for hire, or smugglers who stumble into discoveries best left untouched. What matters is that they are more than individuals. They are a living unit, defined as much by their shared reputation as by their submersible.

What Holds a Crew Together

Trust, supplies, and oath.

Every crew is a fragile alliance of desperate people inside a fragile shell of steel. What binds them is not merely circumstance, but three invisible threads:

Trust

The abyss allows no liars. When the hull groans or the oxygen runs low, hesitation can kill. Crews survive by trusting that each member will do their duty — pilot steering true, engineer sealing leaks, medic watching the wounded. Without trust, a crew fractures, and the abyss devours them one by one.

Supplies

Oxygen, food, fuel — these are the glue of loyalty. Crews share everything because they must. A diver's breath may depend on a cylinder filled by another's hand. Every salvage haul is divided not just as profit, but as a promise that all will eat, all will breathe, all will endure.

Oath

Spoken or unspoken, every crew has an oath. Some swear on blood, others on faith, others on nothing more than the need to see another dawn. Oaths may bind them to vengeance, to treasure, to survival itself. They give shape to loyalty, turning strangers into family.

The abyss is endless. No one can face it alone. A crew's strength is not its weapons or its hull — it is the invisible bond that keeps them together when the dark presses close.



The Unknown Below

Leviathans as Events, Not Monsters

The abyss is not a place where things live in ways the surface could easily understand. When divers speak of leviathans, they do not mean mere predators or beasts that can be catalogued, measured, or slain. Leviathans are events. They are phenomena that leave survivors doubting their senses, wondering whether they truly saw what they believe.

A leviathan encounter is not about statistics or anatomy. It is about what it does to the crew. A sudden sonar return that seems larger than a city block. A tremor felt through the hull, too rhythmic to be tectonic. A shadow passing over floodlights that extinguishes all colour and leaves only grey.

Sometimes nothing is seen at all. The crew might glimpse a pressure wake or feel the hull groan as something passes nearby. Perhaps they hear voices in the static, or find their oxygen gauges spinning nonsense. When a leviathan is present, reality bends. The event is the monster.

The abyss does not reward heroics in these moments. Leviathans cannot be harpooned or reasoned with. They pass like storms, and the best a crew can do is endure.

Abyssal Anomalies and Ruins

The deep is littered with remnants of both humanity and things far older. Some anomalies can be explained by geology, pressure shifts, or broken machinery. Others resist explanation entirely.

Divers have reported glowing plumes that move against currents, towers of basalt carved with markings no faction claims, and entire sonar maps shifting overnight as

if the seabed itself has turned. Sometimes wrecks are found at depths no vessel could have reached, their hulls perfectly intact but their interiors long stripped by unseen hands.

Ruins are equally unsettling. Some are clearly human, relics of drowned cities or experimental domes lost in the early days of collapse. Others appear impossibly ancient, cut into trench walls or scattered across abyssal plains, bearing patterns that recall neither human culture nor natural formation.

For crews, anomalies are double-edged. They may offer salvage, knowledge, or rare materials. Yet every discovery carries risk. A ruined temple might conceal a collapse waiting to happen. A glowing vent may spew toxic gases. An unmapped wreck might already belong to another crew, watching from the dark.

The abyss thrives on mystery. Chase your answers, but the darkness never provides certainty too easily. The unknown is the setting's greatest resource.

Pressure

Describe pressure as a constant presence, not just a number on a gauge. Your character will hear the hull groaning, feel the air thicken in their lungs, or sense a headache building behind their eyes. Dials quiver, bubbles shrink or expand in their view, gloves stiffen as the water presses harder. Remember that their bodies are not meant to survive here.

Darkness

Darkness is never passive. It is an active force that swallows beams and reshapes space. Lamps illuminate only a cone, sonar returns a vague smear, shadows move at the edge of vision. Darkness makes

distance uncertain — what looks near might be far, what looks small might be immense. Beyond the circle of your lights is a world you cannot control.

Sonar

Sonar is a language of ghosts. Every ping is a question, every return a half-truth. Sonar contacts are not crisp shapes but suggestions: a cluster of points, a distorted loop, a faint echo that repeats when it should not. Sometimes the sea floor answers as if alive. Sometimes signals vanish mid-return. Sonar is both lifeline and liar, and its ambiguity builds tension.



The abyss is endless, a stage of crushing pressure and eternal night. Its domes cling like candles in the dark, its crews flicker like sparks against a storm. No map can tame it, no creed can bind it. The abyss does not care if you endure — it only waits, patient and immense. And now, as the lamps dim and the trench yawns wide, your story begins.

It is the most mysterious and least explored place on Earth, where one feels both wonder and terror at the same time.” — Jacques-Yves Cousteau

Part II: Rules Summary

Core Resolution System

At its heart, *Midnight Abyss* uses the Ruled system, a simple dice pool system designed to keep tension high and outcomes dramatic. The mechanics are easy to learn but flexible enough to cover exploration, salvage, survival, and conflict under pressure.

Building the Dice Pool

Characters do not have broad attributes like Strength or Intelligence. Instead, their effectiveness comes from the skills they know, how they specialise, the aptitudes they possess, and the traits that set them apart.

When a player attempts an action where failure is possible or dramatic, they build a dice pool:

The **base die** comes from their level of training in the skill.

- Untrained characters roll a **d20**.
- Trained characters roll a **d12**.
- Experienced characters roll a **d10**.
- Masters roll a **d8 or d6**, representing expertise honed by long practice.

Aptitudes increase the number of skill dice rolled. A character with a secondary aptitude rolls two dice of their skill type, while a primary aptitude grants three.

Traits may add an additional d12 if relevant to the task, more than one can be rolled at a time if more than one is appropriate. They also provide one automatic success in a very specific circumstance, allowing characters to shine

in the niche where they excel. More detail is provided on page 20.

The Target Number

All dice are rolled against a fixed **Target Number of 5**. Any die that shows a 5 or less counts as a **success**. The difficulty of a task is measured not by adjusting the target number, but by how many successes are required:

Routine tasks usually require 1 success. Risky or complex tasks may need 2–3 successes. Extreme situations can demand 4 or more successes, often with added complications.

A mixed outcome occurs when the difficulty is missed by one success, either naturally or after spending Drama.

This system ensures that even highly skilled characters face tension, while the untrained can still succeed—if fortune favours them.

Successes and Drama

If the player rolls enough successes to meet or exceed the difficulty, the action succeeds. If they fall short, they may still scrape through by spending **Drama**.

Drama is a shared narrative currency representing adrenaline, desperation, and the thin line between survival and disaster. Players may spend 1 Drama to:

- **Spend to increase your total successes, improving the result to a mixed outcome.**
- **Reroll one die in their pool.**

This mechanic keeps the spotlight on player choice, balancing luck with the crew's dwindling reserves of resolve.

Traits and Automatic Successes

Traits are more than flavour. Each Trait provides:

- An **automatic success** when the situation matches its description (for example, *Hull Rat* automatically succeeds at manoeuvring through tight spaces).
- An **extra die** (usually d12) whenever its theme could reasonably apply to the roll.

This makes Traits powerful but specific. They highlight moments where characters feel unique, reminding everyone why this individual belongs in the abyss.

The Feel of Play

The dice system is designed to be fast, tense, and cinematic. Rolling high dice types like d20 reflects uncertainty, while rolling low dice types like d6 reflects mastery. Success is always possible, but never certain. The abyss does not care for fairness, and the dice make sure players feel that truth at the table.

Skills and Aptitudes

Skills in *Midnight Abyss* represent the areas of training and knowledge that allow divers, scavengers, and specialists to survive in the depths. While the full game contains a broader list, this quickstart narrows the options to the essentials.

Each character begins play trained in several skills. Training determines the size of die rolled when using that skill. An untrained character rolls a d20, while trained characters roll a d12. As they gain experience, skills may improve to d10, d8, or even d6, representing rare mastery.

The Quickstart Skill List

For this condensed ruleset, use the following core skills, some of which are amalgamations of skills from the full list:

Pilot: For steering submersibles, drones, or rigs, navigating currents, or manoeuvring through wrecks.

Repair: For fixing systems, jury-rigging in emergencies, or maintaining life support.

Knowledge: For interpreting science, scanning anomalies, or applying technical or academic expertise.

Diving: For underwater manoeuvres, breath control, cutting into wrecks, or recovering resources.

Armed Combat / Ranged Weapons / Brawling: For close or ranged combat, whether in suits, subs, or by hand.

Medicine: For stabilising wounds, treating strain, or improvising care under pressure.

Negotiate / Deceive / Intimidation: For persuasion, bluffing, trade, or exerting presence in tense situations.

Investigation / Notice: For searching wrecks, spotting details, or piecing together clues.

Stamina / Survival / Willpower / Stealth: For enduring pressure, cold, hypoxia, exhaustion, or navigating hostile environments undetected.

Aptitudes

Aptitudes represent **innate capability** — a character's natural talent, instinct, or predisposition toward a particular kind of action. They measure what a person is *able* to do under pressure, not what they have been formally taught.

Aptitude reflects reflex, intuition, and adaptability — the difference between someone who *learns* how to fix a valve and someone who can *feel* when a machine is about to fail. Training and skill can sharpen or focus an aptitude, but the underlying potential is already there.

A character may hold either a **Primary Aptitude** or a **Secondary Aptitude** in a skill area:

- **Primary Aptitude:** Strong natural affinity; the character performs with confidence or instinctive ease.
- **Secondary Aptitude:** A weaker but still noticeable inclination or knack for the task.

Even without formal skill, a high Aptitude allows a character to react capably, improvise under stress, and find creative solutions — though practice and training remain the difference between potential and mastery.

Example in Play

Mira is a skilled **Pilot** with a **Secondary Aptitude**. Her piloting skill is trained to d12. When steering her crew's sub through a collapsing trench, she builds her pool. Normally, she would roll one d12 for her skill, but her Secondary Aptitude grants her a second d12. She also adds a Trait, *Current Reader*, which gives her an extra d12.

Mira rolls three dice total: two d12s from her Secondary Aptitude and one d12 from her Trait. Each result of 5 or lower counts as a success. It is enough to steer the sub clear of danger, though just barely.

Skills and the Abyss

Every dive, every salvage, and every battle in the trenches is shaped by skills and aptitudes. They define not only what the characters can attempt, but how far they can push themselves before the abyss pushes back. Characters without Aptitudes can still succeed, but crews that spread expertise across the list will find themselves better prepared to endure the unknown.

Traits and Specialisations

Traits are the unique qualities, quirks, and experiences that make each character in *Midnight Abyss* distinct. They are more than flavour — They represent the edge that keeps a diver alive in an environment that swallows the unprepared.

Every player character begins play with **one free Trait** chosen from the general list and **one Role Trait** tied to the function they serve in the crew. These two choices already set a character apart from ordinary divers and make clear what they contribute to the group.

Role Traits

Role Traits represent the professional function of a character within a salvage crew or expedition team. Each is focused, practical, and directly linked to situations that will arise during play.

For example:

Captain: Gains an automatic success when coordinating allies under stress. Gains an extra die when using leadership or negotiation with the crew.

Pilot: Gains an automatic success when making evasive manoeuvres or precision navigation. Gains an extra die on general piloting or course adjustment.

Engineer: Gains an automatic success when performing an emergency repair on hull, oxygen, or power systems. Gains an extra die on jury-rigging and mechanical analysis.

Diver: Gains an automatic success when working in hostile underwater environments. Gains an extra die on salvage preparation or extravehicular activity.

Medic: Gains an automatic success when stabilising a critical wound. Gains an extra die on broader medical or triage work.

Quartermaster: Gains an automatic success when evaluating or managing supplies. Gains an extra die on logistics and haggling.

Role Traits give mechanical benefits but also spotlight each character's place in the crew, ensuring that every role is useful, and guiding how each character shines in tense moments.

Specialisations

Specialisations allow characters to focus further within the skills they are trained in. Mechanically, a Specialisation is treated as a Trait:

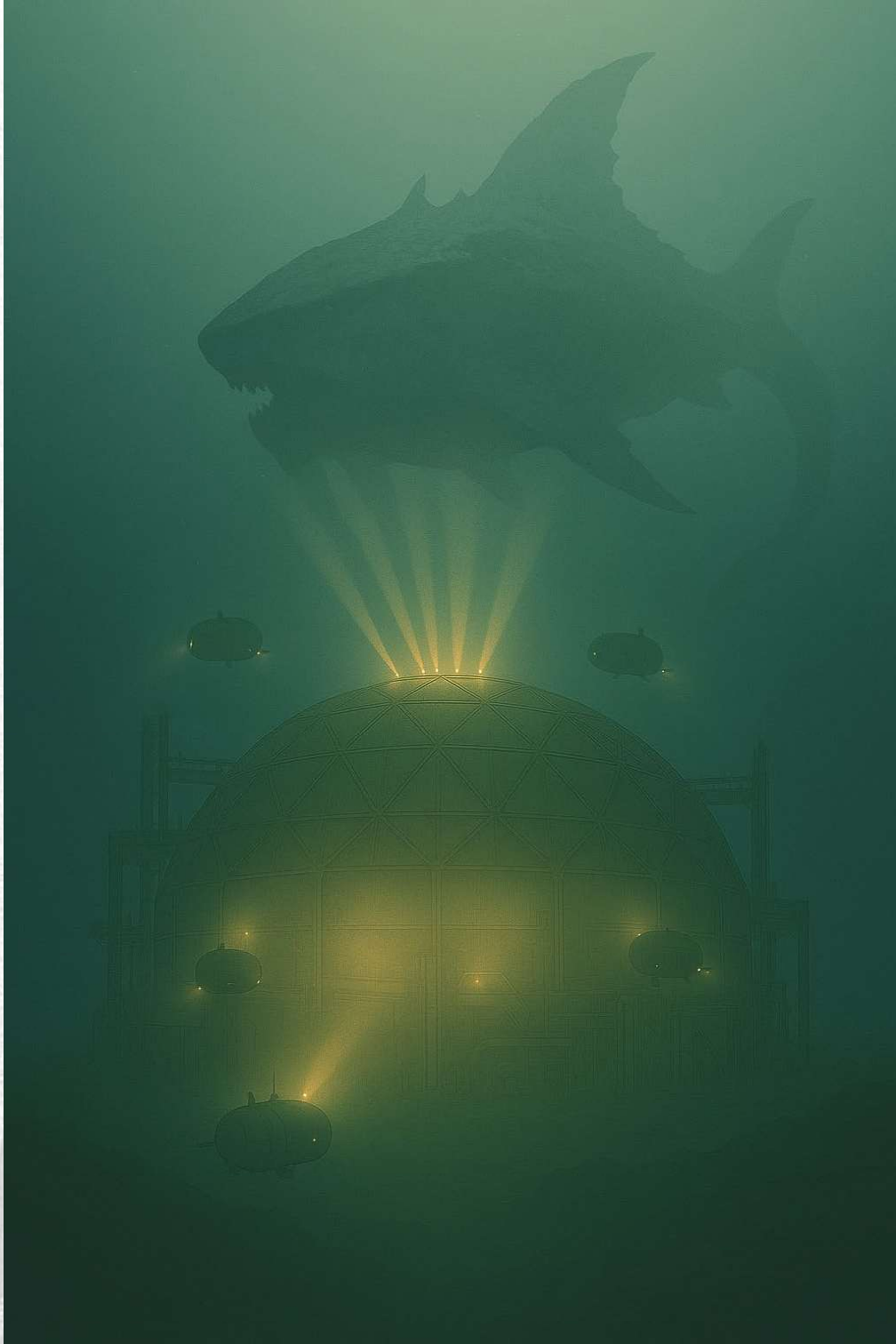
- It grants one automatic success in a narrowly defined task.
- It also provides an extra die when the Specialisation is relevant to the roll.

For example, a Pilot trained in general navigation may take the Specialisation *Trench Runner*, gaining an automatic success when steering through narrow canyons and an extra die when piloting or manoeuvring under stressful conditions. A Medic might take *Field Surgeon*, granting an automatic success when stabilising a critically injured crew member who would otherwise die before reaching full medical care and an extra die when providing medical attention under pressure — limited tools, poor lighting, confined spaces, or while the sub lurches and groans around them.

Specialisations add flavour and depth to skills, encouraging players to describe the unique training or background that sets their diver apart. Over time, they can accumulate to reflect the scars, lessons, and victories won in the abyss.

Traits in Play

Traits and Specialisations should always feel powerful. They are the moments when the character's history, training, or personality turns the tide. Directors are encouraged to prompt players to use Traits whenever possible — not as exceptions, but as the foundation of who the characters are. The abyss tests everyone, but Traits show why this crew in particular is able to endure.



Traits (Summary)

This list provides a **fast-play version** of Traits. Each Trait either grants **+1 Success** automatically in a specific situation or a **+d12 Trait Die** when making a relevant roll. Roles, Free, and Specialisations are all **types of Traits**. The full expanded list is in the Core Traits chapter.

Fast Trait List (examples):

- **Pressure Hardened** – Gains **+1 Success** against routine depth/pressure strain; rolls an extra **+d12** when resisting sudden pressure spikes.
- **Iron Lungs** – Gains **+1 Success** for breath-holding and calm endurance; rolls an extra **+d12** in extreme hypoxia or gas-starved dives.
- **Deepwater Training** – Gains **+1 Success** on standard dive procedures; rolls an extra **+d12** for complex underwater manoeuvres under stress.
- **Scraper** – Gains **+1 Success** when repairing simple salvage fixes; rolls an extra **+d12** when jury-rigging under time pressure.
- **Cold-Blooded** – Gains **+1 Success** against ordinary cold exposure; rolls an extra **+d12** when resisting extreme hypothermia conditions.
- **Quick Study** – Gains **+1 Success** when recalling newly learned information; rolls an extra **+d12** when attempting an unfamiliar system in play.
- **Survivor** – Gains **+1 Success** in common survival checks; rolls an extra **+d12** when enduring compounded hazards (cold, stress, and hunger combined).
- **Medic** – Gains **+1 Success** for first aid and stabilisation; rolls an extra **+d12** for surgery or biotech tasks under stress.
- **Hunter** – Gains **+1 Success** for routine tracking or striking prey; rolls an extra **+d12** when stalking or fighting hostile predators.
- **Steady Hand** – Gains **+1 Success** for routine shots or calm piloting; rolls an extra **+d12** when acting under crossfire or extreme pressure.
- **Engineer** – Gains **+1 Success** for scheduled maintenance; rolls an extra **+d12** for emergency system repairs mid-crisis.
- **Intimidating Presence** – Gains **+1 Success** for routine coercion; rolls an extra **+d12** when facing larger groups or superior opponents.
- **Trenchborn** – Gains **+1 Success** in everyday trench navigation and darkness; rolls an extra **+d12** when enduring extreme hadal environments.
- **League Raider** – Gains **+1 Success** for raiding familiar targets; rolls an extra **+d12** when striking in hostile or unknown waters.
- **Union Citizen** – Gains **+1 Success** on bureaucratic dealings; rolls an extra **+d12** when invoking Union law against resistance.
- **Confederacy Faithful** – Gains **+1 Success** in ordinary rites or daily faith practice; rolls an extra **+d12** when resisting fear, despair, or abyssal visions.
- **Sharp-Eyed** – Gains **+1 Success** for spotting everyday detail; rolls an extra **+d12** when detecting ambushes or hidden threats.

Survival Rules

Life in the abyss is not measured only by courage or skill. It is measured in breaths, in the steady hum of scrubbers, in the hiss of valves, and in the way a diver watches the needle of an oxygen gauge with more reverence than any altar. Survival mechanics ensure that this constant pressure remains present in the game without overwhelming play. They remind players that every expedition into the dark is a gamble with their most precious resource: air.

The Oxygen Track

Every character's suit is fitted with an oxygen supply that is tracked during dives. By default, a standard dive suit has **five boxes** on its Oxygen Track. Each box represents a measure of breathable air that can be depleted through exertion, environmental hazards, or mishap. Advanced suits may carry more, but the baseline assumption is five.

Whenever a diver takes damage to their systems, or engages in strenuous activity, the Director may call for an **Oxygen Roll**. Failure costs one or more boxes. In this way, oxygen is not a distant abstraction but a ticking clock that can turn even routine dives into tense affairs.

Hypoxia Stages

When a diver's Oxygen Track is reduced to zero, they are not immediately dead. Instead, they enter the stages of **hypoxia** — the slow starvation of the brain and body as air runs out. These stages act as a narrative countdown.

Warning Signs: The diver feels dizzy, clumsy, or unfocused. Actions are possible but at higher risk.

Impairment: Fine control slips away. Speech is slurred, coordination falters, and rolls involving precision become harder.

Blackout: The diver collapses, consciousness slipping away. Unless rescued, their fate is sealed.

Death: Without intervention, the body surrenders. The abyss claims another.

Shared Oxygen vs. Personal Supplies

Many vessels and stations maintain shared oxygen reserves in addition to personal tanks. A submersible, for example, may have a communal reserve that all divers draw from when aboard, while EVA suits rely on their individual cylinders.

This dual system creates interesting decisions. Do the crew top up their personal tanks from the shared supply before a dangerous dive, leaving less for emergencies later? Do they risk venturing deeper with only what is strapped to their backs? Oxygen management is less about numbers and more about narrative choice, reinforcing the sense that survival is always provisional.

Food and Water

Unlike oxygen, food and water are not usually tracked in boxes. Instead, they serve as part of the **narrative backdrop**. Crews eat algae cakes, thin broth, or salted fish between missions, and trade in supplies is constant. Shortages may set the scene for tension in settlements, sparking

riots or desperate barter, but in day-to-day play food is not meant to slow the pace of the story. Only when scarcity becomes part of the drama — a storm cutting off resupply, or a failed salvage leaving bellies empty — should it take centre stage.

Teamwork and Drama

The abyss is not endured alone. Every dive, every salvage, every brush with the unknown is a trial of the crew together. No single diver can cut through a wreck, pilot a submersible, patch a hull, and hold their breath against the crushing dark all at once. Teamwork is more than an option — it is survival itself. The mechanics of teamwork and drama exist to reinforce this truth.

presses a sealant while the quartermaster keeps the patient calm.

Helping does not remove risk. A helper is exposed to the same dangers: their torch may sputter, their gloves may slip, or they may lose oxygen while straining against a stubborn hatch. This keeps teamwork dramatic, not cost-free.

Helping Another Character

When one character attempts an action, another may declare they are assisting. Mechanically, this means **pooling successes**. The primary actor rolls their full pool counting their successes, the person assisting rolls just their skill dice, including aptitude if appropriate adding any successes to the primary actors. If together they meet or exceed the difficulty, the action succeeds.

This system allows for small contributions to carry weight. Even a single success from a supporting diver may be the difference between cutting through a wreck before the hull collapses or failing to reseal a breached line before the air is gone. Importantly, the Director should describe these combined efforts cinematically — the cutter sparks a torch, while their partner steadies the plating; the pilot holds the sub steady while the engineer bolts on a patch; the medic

Spending Drama

Drama is the crew's most precious intangible resource — the representation of grit, improvisation, and willpower under pressure. Players can spend **Drama Points** in the following ways:

Reroll a Die: Spend 1 Drama to reroll any die in the pool. This represents sudden clarity, a flash of luck, or sheer stubbornness.

Negate Oxygen Loss: Spend 1 Drama to prevent the loss of a single Oxygen Box. This can be narrated as calming breath, sealing a leak at the last moment, or activating a backup regulator.

Delay Hypoxia: Spend 1 Drama to hold off advancing one stage down the Hypoxia Track for the current scene. The diver pushes past dizziness, rallies from despair, or clings to consciousness by force of will.

Drama points are not limitless, and their expenditure should always feel weighty. Encourage players to describe what their character does to justify the spend. Every point spent is another moment of the abyss tightening its grip, demanding more from the crew in return.

Encourage players to lean into the fiction: describe the sweat under the mask, the way the hull groans like a living thing, or how a crewman's voice cracks when they say "*We have enough air, right?*" Mechanics are there to serve this atmosphere, not replace it. The abyss becomes terrifying

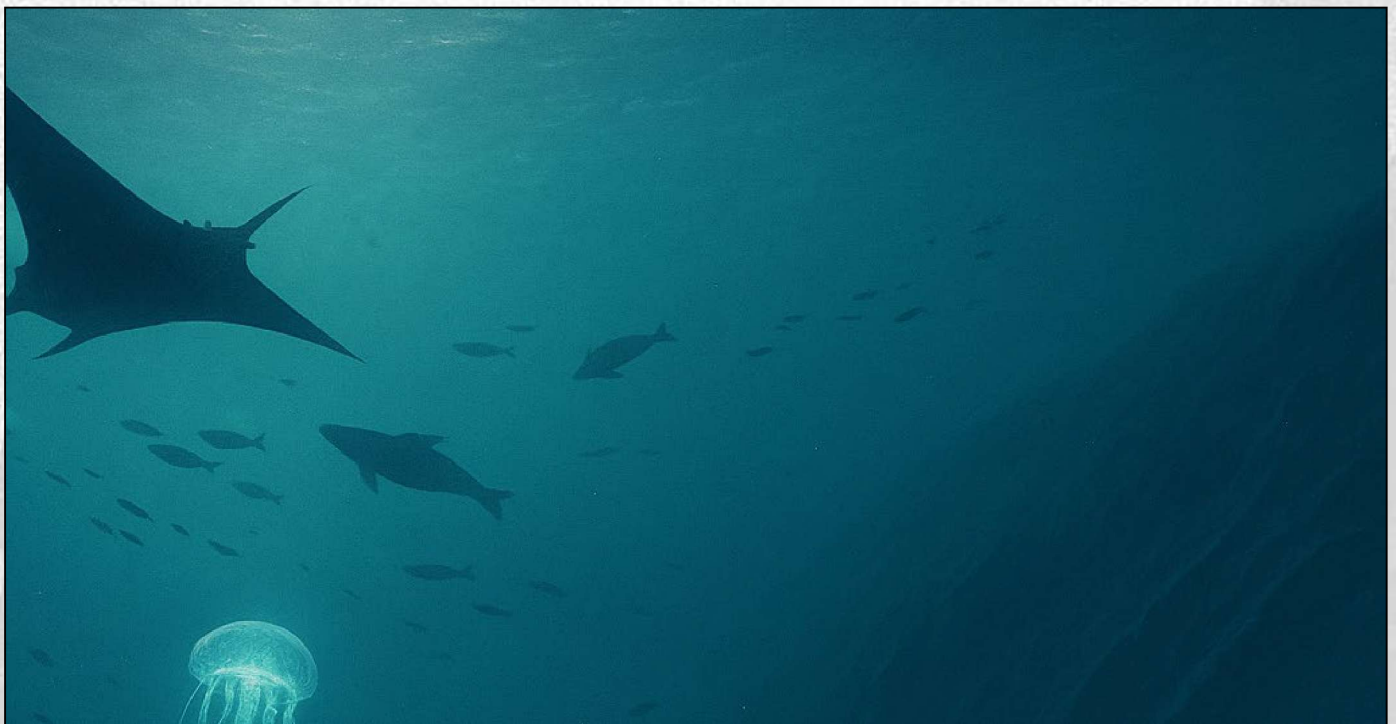
Play the Tension, Not the Maths

The abyss is not a numbers game. Oxygen tracks, success pools, and drama points are tools, not the story itself. The point is not whether you have three boxes left or two — it is how that dwindling supply feels in play. A diver breathing hard as their gauge dips into the red should be described, felt, and feared.

not when numbers fall, but when those numbers are made real through story.

Conclusion

Teamwork and Drama reinforce the central truth of *Midnight Abyss*: no one survives alone. Mechanics ensure that assistance is meaningful, but also dangerous. Drama points allow moments of defiance, but they are finite and costly. Together, these systems keep the game balanced between hope and despair, reminding players that in the deep, survival is never guaranteed — only borrowed.



The Posiden Descent

GM Introduction

The Posiden Descent is a quickstart scenario for Midnight Abyss. The players take the roles of the crew of a Posidon-class submersible, a vessel that has suffered catastrophic mechanical failure during a routine run. The ballast tanks have jammed open and the vessel is sinking slowly but steadily towards the seabed, hundreds of feet below. Gauges indicate that impact will occur in less than an hour. The hull may endure the pressure of depth, but it will not endure a hard crash.

The purpose of the scenario is to highlight time pressure, claustrophobic tension, and the struggle between teamwork and panic. The abyss is always pressing closer. Player effort determines whether the vessel halts its descent, strikes bottom softly, or suffers a catastrophic crash.

The Posidon-class is a familiar workhorse of Abyssal Corp. Its name is a deliberate misspelling of Poseidon, made to secure an easier trademark. This is a common source of gallows humour among crews, who joke that the missing letter is the price paid in reliability. Every groan of the hull becomes an opportunity for someone to mutter, “Should have paid for the extra letter.” The joke can be introduced as an early way to set the grim mood.

The Sub’s Name

This Posiden-class tramp submersible has a name painted in flaking letters along its hull. By default it is known as **Better Days**, a name that speaks to rust, debt, and the crew’s stubborn will to keep going.

Director Guidance: Allow the players to rename the vessel if they wish. Choosing a name gives them immediate ownership of the craft they are about to fight for. The name should feel personal, wry, or battered, never sleek or glamorous.

Alternative Names

- *Marlin*
- *Brine Dog*
- *Lucky Break*

Encourage the group to pick one, or invent their own. Whatever they decide, make it clear that this sub is their livelihood and their burden, a vessel that has carried them into the abyss and may yet be their coffin.



The Situation

The Posiden-class sub *Better Days* is failing. Its ballast system has jammed, and the vessel is sliding ever deeper into the abyss. Every few minutes it sinks further, no matter what the crew does. The pressure rises, alarms echo, and the lights flicker as the seabed creeps closer.

Each round of play represents a short span of time as the descent continues. At least

one repair check should be attempted each round, or the crew risks losing control entirely.

Some actions — engineering fixes, manual overrides, emergency power dumps, or jury-rigging the pumps — directly work toward restoring the ballast. These count toward the ultimate repair of the system.

Other actions cannot halt the descent, but they matter all the same. Driving off predators, rerouting failing power, or keeping panicked crew members under control buys precious time. These efforts slow the vessel's fall, protect against complications, or keep the team alive long enough for the engineers to work.

The descent will not stop until the ballast system is fully repaired. Progress comes in pieces, and even strong efforts may only

delay the inevitable. Only once the full tally of repair progress is reached, and a decisive final attempt succeeds, will the vessel stabilise. Until then, the abyss is always pulling you down.

What Counts Toward Repair

- **Counts:** Engineering attempts, manual overrides, jury-rigging, EVA clamps, power dumps, or other creative actions directly engaging the ballast system.
- **May Count:** Support that clearly aids repairs (rerouting power, holding valves steady).
- **Does Not Count:** Fighting predators, morale support, or fixing secondary systems — these buy time, but do not move the crew closer to a True Repair.

Framing the Descent

This section is intended for the Director alone. Before beginning the first scene, pause to frame the situation. Describe the vessel already sliding into darkness, the sense of pressure on the hull, and the tight time limit. Explain to the players that every roll represents part of the crew's struggle to hold the sub together and slow its descent. Stress that even strong rolls usually only buy time, and that a true repair is the only way to survive.

Keep the story in the foreground. Mechanics exist to support tension. After every roll, tie the outcome back to fiction: sparks flying, metal straining, shadows outside, or moments of relief. Early stages should feel like small victories and diagnosis, middle stages should introduce predators and stress, and late stages should force desperate gambles. This ensures the descent is both mechanical and dramatic.

Scene One: The Realisation

Read Aloud

The vessel jolts. Alarms shriek through the corridors as red light floods the cabin. The hull groans under pressure, metal flexing and sighing like a living thing. Gauges flash red — the ballast tanks are jammed, and the Posiden is sinking. You can feel it in your stomach: the faint, steady pull downward. The abyss presses on every side, shadows circling the external lights. The seabed waits a few hundred feet below. If nothing changes, you will meet it in less than an hour.

Scene One: The Realisation

Director Note: Use this opening to anchor the crew in crisis and establish the countdown clock. The sub is descending slowly — not yet in free fall, but beyond stability. Every repair attempt or delay will cost precious time.

The alarms echo long after the first jolt. Red light pools across consoles and faces, catching sweat, oil, and fear in equal measure. The air hums with static and heat. Somewhere deep in the hull, a steady vibration marks the sub's slow descent — the sound of time itself running out.

Now that the shock has passed, the crew scramble to make sense of the readings. Systems stutter but still respond. The ballast tanks remain locked, but there is no flooding — not yet. The sub is wounded but alive.

Encourage players to describe how they react in these first moments: do they dive for the controls, reach for tools, or freeze and listen to the groaning metal? Every action here establishes their role and their instincts under pressure.

Outside, the lights catch drifting shapes that vanish as quickly as they appear. The smell of burning insulation and the hiss of venting air hint at dangers yet unseen.

Scene Two: Early Repairs

Director Note: Early depth band. Only limited successes count toward the True Repair tally, but every roll affects time and descent speed. Extra successes slow the fall, not the tally. Let players feel progress but never safety.

Steam hisses through ruptured pipes as the Posiden groans against the crushing dark. The air tastes of iron and burnt ozone. Sparks leap from panels as the crew wrestle with failing systems, their movements sharp and frantic beneath the blood-red lights. Every clang of a wrench echoes like a heartbeat.

These first repairs are desperate improvisation — patching lines, diverting power, and cranking valves by hand. Even the smallest success slows the descent, though the rhythm of the fall never truly stops. The sub feels alive, trembling, breathing through its wounds.

Encourage each player to describe how their character helps: the mechanic bent over exposed wiring, the commander barking orders through rising static, the medic holding someone steady as pressure gauges jitter and scream. Even those without technical training can matter — clearing debris, fetching tools, keeping hands steady.

Show the strain of each attempt: scorched gloves, sparks biting at skin, the sharp

snap of a bolt giving way. This is survival by inches, and the abyss is patient.

Scene Three: Predators Stirring

Director Note: This is a narrative hazard, not necessarily combat. Treat the predators as external stress and complication. Dealing with them costs time; ignoring them risks damage or injury. The descent never pauses.

Something moves in the dark.

At first, it is only a tremor through the hull — a dull, resonant thud that reverberates through the deck plates. Then sonar flickers. Shapes drift beyond the lights, vast and slow, their outlines warping and vanishing in the shifting silt.

Noise, heat, and blood have drawn attention. Whether scavengers, hunters, or simply curious, the creatures circle closer, brushing against the hull with scraping, exploratory pressure. The sub shivers with every contact.

Describe the sensations before revealing anything: the hollow echo of movement outside, the staccato ping of sonar distortion, the unsettling realisation that something is watching. The abyss is not empty — it never was.

The crew must decide: will they risk precious minutes driving the predators off, or keep working and hope the creatures lose interest? Any decision has cost. Fighting burns time and oxygen. Ignoring them invites disaster.

Allow for cleverness — decoy lights, controlled power surges, flares through an emergency tube. Each option changes the risk, not the tension. Even success feels temporary. The shadows always return.

Scene Four: Desperation

Director Note: This is where interpersonal stress and resource pressure collide. Apply strain, drama, or stress mechanics as needed. Failure here rarely kills — it divides, isolates, and tests resolve. Build to the moment of unity or collapse before the final push.

Halfway down, the air turns stale. The lights flicker and dim. The hull creaks with every metre, as if the ocean is whispering through the metal. The crew are sweating, shaking, and snapping at one another. The abyss is winning — not through violence, but attrition.

Small systems begin to fail. A console dies mid-command. The oxygen scrubbers choke on moisture. A breaker explodes in a burst of sparks that leaves the smell of burning plastic. Exhaustion sets in.

Tension feeds on itself. Doubt becomes anger; fear becomes blame. Let arguments flare — short, sharp bursts of panic that fade into heavy silence. The abyss teaches patience, but not mercy.

Describe the sensory exhaustion: the weight of helmets pressing on temples, the vibration of pumps rattling in bones, the faint metallic taste in every breath. The sub feels smaller now. The walls seem closer.

Encourage players to make hard choices: treat the wounded or continue repairs, conserve oxygen or risk more strain. Every act feels like a gamble. Every success feels like defiance.

Scene Five: The Final Descent

Director Note: Final depth band. All possible successes count toward the True Repair tally. Require the final decisive roll to determine outcome. Use the crash severity bands for resolution. This is the climax — success means survival with consequence, failure means the abyss claims its due.

The seabed rises in the floodlights — a pale, rippling plain of silt and wreckage that drifts like smoke. The hull shudders, metal singing under pressure. Every light in the cabin flickers. The Posiden is minutes from impact.

The air is heavy and wet. Tools slip in sweating hands. Each clang echoes through the vessel like a gunshot. Outside, movement stirs again — the silhouettes of predators, drawn by noise and desperation.

This is the moment for reckless brilliance. Every idea, every risk, every spark of ingenuity matters. Encourage the crew to attempt the impossible: venting ballast manually, rerouting power through scorched conduits, diving outside the sub to release jammed valves by hand. Let their courage be the only light left.

Describe the climax through sound and motion — the rising wail of alarms, the heavy groan of the hull, the sudden silence as systems strain beyond endurance. Then, the resolution: a long pause, a shudder, and

the slow realisation that the descent has stopped. Or not.

If they succeed, the sub steadies, battered but whole. If they fail, the impact is thunder and steel, the ocean roaring into every seam. Either way, the abyss is listening.

Resolution

If the ballast holds, the Posiden steadies. Gauges level out. Alarms die, leaving an oppressive silence broken only by breathing. The crew hang weightless for a heartbeat, unsure if they have stopped sinking or simply paused between heartbeats of disaster.

Allow a moment for roleplay — exhaustion, disbelief, maybe laughter. Let them feel the narrowness of their survival.

If the vessel crashes, draw the scene in shades of noise and chaos. Metal screams. Water bursts through seams. Lights explode. Describe injuries and confusion, then fade into quiet — the survivors coughing in the dark, the slow groan of shifting pressure. From there, play can shift naturally into survival on the seabed or desperate rescue.

Director Note — See Crash Severity table for graded outcomes. Treat success as survival with consequence, not safety. Every ending should feel earned.

Tone and Flavour

This scenario is designed to keep tension high from beginning to end. Every round the abyss presses closer. Even when the crew succeed they can only slow the descent, not end it, until the True Repair is complete. Complications from predators, failing systems, and crew stress layer on top of the sinking clock to create narrative variety and prevent monotony.

Players are encouraged to roleplay their efforts and to think creatively. Not every character must repair the ballast directly, but every character must contribute in some way to survival. The scenario balances technical fixes with drama and danger, ensuring that the final victory, if it comes, feels earned.



Editor's Note: Fast Skills and Character Options

The pregenerated characters in this quickstart use the **Fast Skill List**, a streamlined version of the core rules designed for one-shot or introductory play. Each crew member has a focused selection of abilities and simplified Traits that highlight the pressure, teamwork, and danger at the heart of *The Posiden Descent*.

In the **full rulebook**, the complete skill list expands these options to include specialisations, and additional trait interactions. Characters created with the full system possess greater flexibility and depth, allowing for broader campaign play beyond the immediate crisis.

For the purposes of this quickstart, the Fast Skill framework ensures that play remains quick, tense, and accessible — everything you need to survive one descent into the abyss.

The Crew of the Posiden – Table Handouts

Lieutenant Cale Deren

“Calm voices. Clear orders. You panic, you die.”

Role: Command and coordination under pressure

Primary Skills (D10): Command, Awareness, Tactics

Secondary Skills (D12): Endure, Persuade, Athletics

Trait – Steady Under Pressure

Once per scene, when another crew member fails from panic or stress, roll Command (D10). On success, convert their failure to a partial success and remove one stress.

Personality:

A disciplined officer trained in crisis protocol. Cale hides fear behind efficiency and refuses to admit doubt.

Chief Engineer Lira Voss

“If it can break, I can break it worse — and fix it after.”

Role: Mechanical heart of the crew

Primary Skills (D10): Engineering, Jury-Rig, Endure

Secondary Skills (D12): Awareness, Command, Salvage

Trait – Pressure-Born Fixer

When performing a repair under stress or time pressure, roll one step lower (D10 becomes D8). On success, stabilise one additional failing system beyond the immediate fix.

Personality:

A veteran abyssal mechanic from Abyssal Corp's lower yards. She swears fluently in five dialects and treats the sub like a stubborn pet.

Dr. Mina Corin

“I patch people, not machines — but sometimes, they’re the same thing.”

Role: Medic and morale stabiliser

Primary Skills (D10): Medicine, Awareness, Persuade

Secondary Skills (D12): Jury-Rig, Endure, Salvage

Trait – Compassion Under Fire

When treating a crew member in danger, gain one automatic success but take one stress.

Personality:

A calm, steady hand in chaos. Mina sees triage as confession — everyone’s fears surface when they bleed.

Diver Renn Takura

“If something’s broken, sometimes you have to go outside to fix it.”

Role: EVA specialist and external repair diver

Primary Skills (D10): Athletics, Salvage, Awareness

Secondary Skills (D12): Engineering, Command, Endure

Trait – Abyss-Walker

When outside the vessel or exposed to the abyss, roll one step lower (D10 becomes D8) for Athletics or Awareness. On success, detect an unseen danger or opportunity automatically.

Personality:

Prefers the silence of the deep to the chatter inside. Finds peace in the weight of the abyss that others fear.

Systems Tech Jonah Pell

“The machine’s alive, you just have to learn its moods.”

Role: Electrical and data systems, power routing, and sensors

Primary Skills (D10): Systems, Engineering, Awareness

Secondary Skills (D12): Jury-Rig, Persuade, Endure

Trait – Whisper to the Wires

When working with electrical systems amid chaos (flooding, alarms, or darkness), roll one step lower (D10 becomes D8). On success, restore partial function to one additional linked system (lights, sonar, or comms).

Personality:

Raised in Abyssal Corp’s machine yards. Speaks to systems like they can hear him — and sometimes, they seem to listen.

The Posiden Descent: GM Reference Sheet

Core Setup

- Starting clearance: 500–600 feet above seabed.
- Each round represents approximately 7 minutes.
- Base sink per round: 85 feet.
- Each success reduces the sink by 5 feet.
- At least one repair roll is required each round. Other actions may assist or mitigate complications.

Describe the slow but steady descent reminding players that even small delays are costly. The vessel is always moving downward, and the crew must constantly fight to limit that descent.

True Repair Goal

- Crew must accumulate 18 counted ballast successes.
- Once the threshold is reached, they must succeed on a final decisive repair roll to halt the descent entirely.

The Director should emphasise that slowing the descent is helpful but not sufficient. Only the completion of the full tally and the final decisive attempt will truly stabilise the Posiden.

Success Caps by Depth Band

- 600–450 ft remaining: maximum of 2 counted successes per round.
- 449–300 ft remaining: maximum of 3 counted successes per round.
- 299–150 ft remaining: maximum of 4 counted successes per round.
- 149–0 ft remaining: maximum of 5 counted successes per round.
- Extra successes still reduce descent that round, but do not add to the tally.

The cap ensures that progress is steady but cannot be achieved too early. Players may feel frustration at wasted effort when extra successes do not count toward the tally, and the Director should use that frustration to heighten tension.

What Counts as a Success

- Counts: direct ballast work such as engineering, jury-rigging, manual override, EVA clamp, power dump, or other creative mechanical fixes. Support that directly aids repairs may also count.
- Does not count: predator control, morale management, or repairing secondary systems. These actions may still reduce the sink for that round or prevent additional complications.

The Director should explain that survival requires teamwork. Not every action will move the tally forward, but all actions can matter. Fighting predators or maintaining morale may not fix the ballast, yet they are often essential to give engineers space to work.

Crash Severity Bands (based on final descent that round)

- 0–40 ft: Soft bump. Vessel intact, crew shaken.
- 41–70 ft: Hard landing. Minor leaks and strained systems.
- 71–85 ft: Dangerous crash. Hull twisted, injuries, and flooding.
- 86+ ft (critical failure or penalty): Catastrophic crash. Hull breach and desperate evacuation.

These outcomes give the Director a scale of consequence. Even a soft bump should not feel safe. A hard or dangerous crash can set up extended play, with the crew stranded or fighting to keep the vessel together. A catastrophic crash can lead directly into survival on the seabed.

Running Each Round

1. Announce the current depth remaining.
2. Players declare actions. At least one must be a repair.
3. Roll and total successes.
4. Apply: 85 ft – (5 × successes). Apply the cap for tally.
5. Update the depth.
6. Narrate consequences such as alarms, predators, failing systems, or signs of progress.

The Director should keep the flow brisk. Each round must feel like time is slipping away. Reinforce the image of the abyss

pressing closer and the vessel straining against inevitable pressure.

Director Tips

Remind players that the vessel is always sinking until a True Repair is achieved. Use predators, system failures, and crew stress to create dilemmas and drama. Narrate partial progress vividly. Slowing descent is valuable but temporary. Keep pressure constant. Even good rolls only buy time until the final repair is secured.

The Director is the voice of the abyss. Every description should remind players that their characters are trapped in a fragile shell under unimaginable pressure, and that their survival depends on every decision they make.

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Midnight Abyss is a roleplaying game of salvage crews and desperate explorers who dare what others will not. While most cling to routine in algae farms and rusting corridors, you and your crew take the plunge into wrecks, ruins, and black waters where maps lie leviathans move unseen.

This *Quickstart Guide* gives you everything you need to play:

- A cinematic rules system built on dice pools. Traits. and Drama.
- Four powerful factions vying for survival beneath the waves.
- Rules for oxygen, hypoxia, survival, and teamwork in the deep.
- Pre-generated characters and a tense starting scenario.
- Fiction, vignettes, and art to immerse your crew in the abyss.

In *Midnight Abyss*, leviathans are not monsters to be slain—they are events to be endured. The question is not whether you will win, but whether you can hold together long enough to make it back alive.

THE ABYSS IS WAITING. WILL YOU DESCEND?